



THE RISE AND FALL OF THE DOSA KING

CASE

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THE RISE AND FALL OF THE ‘DOSA KING’¹

INTRODUCTION

The incredible journey from rags to riches of Pitchai Rajagopal was halted on March 29, 2019, by a three-member bench of the Supreme Court of India, which found him guilty of multiple crimes and ordered him to surrender in the next 100 days.² His employees, who considered Rajagopal no less than a messiah were stunned and shattered to learn about his conviction. A man who gave back way more than he received from society today stands discredited and fallen. His supporters, detractors, and his customers wondered what might have led to his catastrophic fall. Equally millions of Saravana Bhavan customers and public at large were in utter disbelief that someone so simple, kind and compassionate can commit something so offensive that the highest court of the country found him guilty.

BACKGROUND

Pitchai Rajagopal (now called ‘Rajagopal’) was born in a village in the southern district of Tamil Nadu state, India, on August 05, 1947. Unlike many business tycoons, he had a humble beginning, as his father was a poor farmer. Rajagopal, a school dropout, moved to Chennai, a bustling metropolis, the capital of Tamil Nadu state. Though he began as a helper wiping down restaurant tables, his move to Chennai ultimately opened many doors for him.³ In 1973, he started a grocery store, and within a few years, he had three branches in Chennai. In 1981, he got an offer to buy a restaurant named ‘Kamatchi Bhavan’, which was making huge losses. Rajagopal purchased the loss-making restaurant with two of his friends as partners. On December 14, 1981, Rajagopal re-launched the acquired restaurant with the new name “Saravana Bhavan” in Chennai. His zeal, zest, and determination resulted in six more restaurants coming up within a decade. Three decades later, Rajagopal had become a leading restaurant baron, having earned the nickname ‘Dosa King’.

THE EARLY YEARS

Rajagopal left his village when he was thirteen years of age, studying in the 5th grade. He left his home without informing his parents in 1960 to work as a salesman in his uncle’s grocery store in Chennai, as farming had become a constant struggle. He could not sustain the tough living and returned to his village. He pursued his schooling for another three grades; after passing his 7th grade, he moved away from his village to Coimbatore, another big city in the south of India, to work in a grocery store. This time, he had the consent of his parents. Having made to work for several hours a day cooking and cleaning for the grocery store employees, he could barely last for three days. Any ordinary individual would have accepted the fate and resigned to a farmer’s life. But Rajagopal was made to write his own fate. Later, he switched to another nearby town and worked as a helper in an eatery. As luck would have it, he landed in the same uncle’s grocery shop in Chennai that he had quit a few years ago. This time, with a stronger resolve and determination, Rajagopal kept toiling and sought opportunities to embark on his entrepreneurial journey. Having struggled for 13 years, since he left his home and tried five different jobs in three different places, in 1973, he started a small grocery store and within three years he had three branches in different parts of Chennai. Rajagopal continued to expand his business, but his calling was somewhere else. With a partner on board, Rajagopal ventured into a business that was largely unexplored and remained under established food entrepreneurs.

RISE OF SARAVANA BHAVAN PRIVATE LIMITED

Indian cuisine is as diverse as its culture, languages, regions and its climate; every major region of India comes with its own unique dishes and subtle variations to popular dishes. With the first branch of Saravana Bhavan started in 1981, in 2022, the group with the name Saravana Bhavan Private Limited has its presence across 30 outlets in South India, 3 in North India, and in 24 countries with 80 outlets across the globe (see Exhibit 1 for a map of locations of Saravana Bhavan's branches and Exhibit 2 for details of country wise branches).⁴ As per a United Nations report, the Indian diaspora, one of the most vibrant and dynamic, is the largest in the world, with 18 million people from the country living outside their homeland in 2020. No wonder why Saravana Bhavan had so many branches in foreign countries.⁵ According to the Saravana Bhavan website, 'A menu of over 350 dishes in 10 categories, prepared to exacting standards and serving 100,000 customers across all the outlets' is a testimony to the impeccable quality and taste that our Saravana Bhavan is famous for. The overall revenue was US \$370 million as of 2017, with the number of employees in India being around 8700 in 2014.⁶

From the beginning, Rajagopal focused on the quality of food and customer experience at a time when these words were not mainstream.⁷ Saravana Bhavan stayed true to its tagline, "High-Quality Vegetarian Food", with consistent taste and quality in all their outlets. The high-quality food and consistent taste at Saravana Bhavan came at an affordable price. The pricing and quality helped Rajagopal to beat the competition offered by restaurants like Sangeetha.⁸ At Saravana Bhavan, good quality food comes with high-quality customer service. Each and every serving staff treated each one of the customers as his personal guest. The commitment to quality at Saravana Bhavan was a result of its employee-friendly and evolved HR practices. In a disorganized and very high turnover restaurant business, Saravana Bhavan never faced employee shortage because hardly anyone left Saravana after joining its rolls. In every outlet, one can find employees having spent their entire working life at the Saravana Bhavan. Be it funding the kids' education paying house rent of the married employees or paying yearly bonuses and covering travel expenses, Rajagopal regarded and treated its employees' way above the standard practices of the food business.

ASTROLOGY AND THE DARK DESIRE

Rajagopal was very religious. The name of his restaurant, Saravana Bhavan, was named after the Hindu God Lord Murugan. He believed all his success was through divine intervention. He was so indebted to the divine that in 2009, he constructed a Hindu temple in his native place, Punnaiyadi, located in Thoothukudi District in Tamil Nadu, at a cost of \$ 0.65 Million.⁹ This temple has become a major tourist attraction in south Tamil Nadu. Rajagopal believed not only in God but also in astrology. He would take all personal and professional decisions after consulting the astrologer. Rajagopal got married to Valli in 1972 as a twenty-five-year-old. In his autobiography, he described his wife as 'God's gift to me, someone who helped him 'in achieving more and more success and in 'safeguarding' his achievements.'¹⁰ Rajagopal and his wife had a healthy married life blessed with two sons. Such was the influence of the astrologer on Rajagopal that, after a few years of married life, he was interested in Krithiga, who was the wife of a chef in Saravana Bhavan. Rajagopal was told by the astrologer that success and good fortune will follow after marrying this lady. With his money and muscle power, he was able to convince Krithiga's husband and married Krithiga. Within a few years of his second marriage, in

1990, Rajagopal's attention had moved to Jeevajothi, 15 years old, daughter of one of his newly joined managers. Meanwhile, Jeevajothi fell in love with one Santhakumar and got married on April 28, 1999. In 2001, one of the famous astrologers in Chennai advised him that if he got married to Jeevajothi, he would take him to the pinnacle of business glory. With the strong desire to have Jeevajothi as his third wife, he conceived and executed one of the cruelest, most sinister, and brutal plots to murder Santhakumar, husband of Jeevajothi.

On October 01, 2001, Rajagopal's henchmen abducted Santhakumar. Later, on October 31, 2001 Santhakumar was killed under the instructions of Rajagopal and his body was found by forest officials in Kodaikanal, a hill town in the Southern Indian State of Tamil Nadu. With due investigations, the police identified and confirmed that the killed person was Santhakumar. Then, the post-mortem was carried out, and the reports concluded that the death was homicidal, as the cause of death was found to be asphyxia due to throttling. Subsequently, charges were framed under various provisions of the IPC, and the trial was conducted based on the complaint lodged by Jeevajothi. After a prolonged legal battle, Rajagopal and some of his aides were convicted and sentenced to different jail terms and fines.

CONVICTION AND SENTENCING

The Lower Court (see Exhibit 3 for the hierarchy of Courts in India), upon evaluation of material on record, convicted the accused-appellants for the offences punishable under various sections of the IPC. Accused appellants appealed before the High Court against the Lower Court verdict; the Lower Court and High Court concluded that the evidence of the prosecution witnesses, along with other supporting evidence, was believable and trustworthy; the motive for the commission of the offence had been proved.¹¹ The High Court verdict was a massive setback for Rajagopal. The Hotel Saravana Bhavan brand remained trusted. The restaurants continued to do well. People continued to eat there as if they did not care what the business owner had done in his personal life. Tasty food served in a clean place was all that mattered to the thousands who trooped in daily to eat at the many Saravana Bhavan outlets across Chennai and elsewhere.⁹

Then Rajagopal and his team appealed to the Supreme Court against the High Court verdict (see Exhibit 4 for details of legal proceedings). The Supreme Court had gone through all the matters and materials relevant to Rajagopal's case and finally, on March 29 2019, gave the final verdict as follows;

"Having regard to the entire material on record and the totality of the facts and circumstances, we find that the evidence on record fully proves the case of the prosecution and that the Lower Court, as well as the High Court, evaluated the material on record in its proper perspective while coming to their conclusion. Thus, the judgment of the Lower Court, as modified by the High Court, need not be interfered with. Hence, these appeals fail and stand dismissed".

After surrendering on July 09, 2019, to serve his life sentence, Rajagopal had a heart attack on July 13, 2019.¹² The Madras High Court granted permission to transfer him from the prison ward of Stanley Medical College Hospital to Vijaya Hospital in Chennai, where Rajagopal, aged 73, died on the morning of July 18 2019.⁶

Rajagopal's death left behind a rich legacy of social service, compassion, generosity, and a business empire to be inherited by his family. His thriving business created opportunities for several young people and families. His friends, family and his employees will find it hard to reconcile the reputation of a successful entrepreneur, philanthropist and great manager with his eventual downfall. His eventual death after a protracted legal battle can potentially damage his image as to how a man of such stature could fall to the very basic human frailties. Often, people find it hard to accept the basic human frailties of those whom they admire. However, Rajagopal's legacy will be remembered as a mix of extraordinary service and human vulnerability. It is for us to decide which side of his life we would like to highlight and which side to overlook. For times to come, Rajagopal will remain a subject of great reverence and controversy.

How does Rajagopal's story challenge you to reflect on your values, consider your convictions, and address unethical decisions while safeguarding personal values and professional integrity?

EXHIBIT 1: SARAVANA BHAVAN BRANCHES LOCATION MAP



(Source: <https://saravanabhavan.com/>)

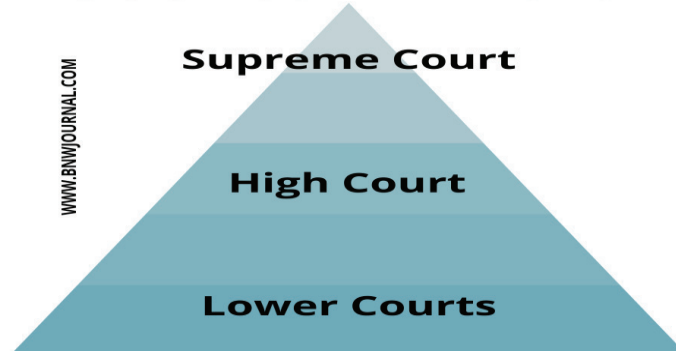
EXHIBIT 2: COUNTRY WISE HSB BRANCHES

S. No	Country	Number of Branches
1	India	33
2	Singapore	3
3	USA	12
4	Canada	3
5	UK	7
6	Belgium	1
7	Sweden	1
8	Australia	5
9	New Zealand	1
10	UAE	13
11	Oman	2
12	Qatar	4
13	Bahrain	1
14	Kuwait	3
15	Saudi Arabia	4
16	Hong Kong	1
17	Thailand	1
18	Malaysia	6
19	Singapore	3
20	Netherlands	2
21	Germany	5
22	South Africa	1
23	France	1

(Source: Compiled by the authors from the company's website)

EXHIBIT 3: HIERARCHY OF COURTS IN INDIA

Hierarchy of Courts in India



(Source: <https://bnwjournal.com/>)

EXHIBIT 4: LEGAL PROCEEDINGS OF RAJAGOPAL

Date	Particulars	Court Verdict	Remarks
October 01,2001	Complaint lodged by JeevaJothi wife of Santakumar stating her husband was abducted by Rajagopal and his henchmen in Velachery police station in Chennai.	Henchmen were convicted and appeal had been made	
November 20,2001	Jeeva Jothi lodged the first information report stating Rajagopal and his henchmen had murdered her husband (Crime No. 1047 of 2001).		
November 23,2001	Rajagopal arrested		
February 27,2002	Rajagopal granted 'default' bail by Lower Court		
April 01,2002	Rajagopal granted regular bail by High Court.		
April 26 ,2004	Judgement given by the Lower Court considering the offence as culpable homicide not amounting to murder.	Ten years of Rigorous Imprisonment (RI) to Rajagopal and a fine of \$ 72,000 under various sections of the Indian Penal Code	Rajagopal's henchmen were also convicted
October 26,2004	Rajagopal has filed an appeal in High Court for reconsidering the verdict given by Lower Court (Crime Appeal No. 637 of 2004)		Appeal was dismissed
March 19,2009	High Court passed the judgment convicting Rajagopal	As per the state government's appeal considering the different section of IPC ,Rajagopal' s 10 years Rigorous imprisonment has been changed to Life Imprisonment	
July,10,2009	Rajagopal filed an appeal in Supreme Court for reconsidering the verdict given by the High Court		Appeal was allowed
March 29,2019	Supreme Court has given the final verdict	Judgement of the Lower Court as modified by the High Court need not be interfered with. Hence these appeals fail and stand dismissed. The court directed Rajagopal to surrender within 100 days.	

(Source: Compiled by the author from <https://indiankanoon.org/doc/1370905/>)

ENDNOTES

¹ This case has been written on the basis of published sources only. Consequently, the perspectives and interpretation presented in this case are not necessarily those of Hotel Saravan Bhavan or any of its employees.

² Madras High Court P. Rajagopal vs The Inspector of Police” on March 19, 2009 accessed March 14,2022, <https://indiankanoon.org/doc/1370905/>.

³ Anjana Shekar, “ The rise and fall of Saravana Bhavan Rajagopal: The ‘dosa king’ with a notorious past,” on July 18,2019 accessed April 21,2022, <https://www.thenewsminute.com/article/rise-and-fall-saravana-bhavan-rajagopal-dosa-king-notorious-past-105678>.

⁴<https://saravanabhavan.com/about-us> accessed on March 15,2022.

⁵ Press Trust of India, “ Indian diaspora largest in the world ,18 million living outside India in 2020 ,says UN,” on January 16,2021 accessed on May 10,2022, <https://theprint.in/india/indian-diaspora-largest-in-the-world-18-million-living-outside-india-in-2020-says-un/586624/>

⁶https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Saravana_Bhavan accessed on April 20, 2022.

⁷ Aditya Bhushan Dwivedi, "The Saravana Bhavan Story: How P Rajagopal went from sleeping on the kitchen floor to becoming the idly king of India,” your story, July 17,2014 updated on September 05,2019 accessed on April 14,2022, <https://yourstory.com/2014/07/saravana-bhavan-story/amp>

⁸<https://bse2nse.com/success-stories-brands-usp/8700-saravana-bhavan-owner-menu-trade-secrets.html> accessed on May 12,2022.

⁹ Nirupama Subramanian, *Murder on the Menu: The Sensational Story of the Tycoon Who Founded Saravana Bhavan* 1st ed. (Juggernaut books, August,2021),166-167.

¹⁰ Rajagopal. P ,*Vetrimeethu Aasai Vaithen* 6th ed.(Manimekalai prasuram,1994), 86-89.

¹¹ Supreme Court of India P. Rajagopal And Ors. Etc. vs The State Of Tamil Nadu on March 29, 2019 accessed April 14,2022, <https://indiankanoon.org/doc/154129732>.

¹²Tsang,Amie “ P. Rajagopal,Restaurant Mogul Convicted of Murder, Dies at 71,” on July 25,2019 accessed on April 30, 2022, <https://www.nytimes.com/2019/07/25/obituaries/rajagopal-saravana-bhavan-dead.html>.